

Most Important Analytical Findings in the Humanitarian Funding Dataset

1. Inverse Relationship Between Severity and Funding

What the data shows: The funding system exhibits a paradoxical inverse relationship between crisis severity and funding coverage. Tier 1 (most overlooked) plans receive only 20.8% average funding despite having the highest gap scores (0.593 average), while Tier 4 (adequately resourced) plans receive 33.1% funding with much lower gap scores (0.154 average). The correlation between severity and funding percentage is weakly positive (0.17), while the correlation between severity and gap score is strongly positive (0.714).

Why it matters analytically: This suggests that funding allocation is not primarily driven by need-based criteria. The gap score formula (severity $\times$ need $\times$ coverage gap) correctly identifies the most severe situations, but these are precisely the plans that receive the least funding. This indicates systematic market failure in humanitarian resource allocation—the "invisible hand" is pointing in the wrong direction.

2. Structural Neglect Penalty: Chronic Crises Receive Less Despite Higher Need

What the data shows: Plans flagged for structural neglect (18+ months at High+ severity) account for 50 of 87 plans in 2025, representing \$26.8B in funding gaps (91% of total) and 288M people in need (99.7% of total). Despite higher average severity (0.77 vs 0.51) and operating environment constraints (7.7 vs 3.9), structurally neglected crises receive only marginally better funding (30.0% vs 26.9%).

Why it matters analytically: The data reveals a "chronic crisis penalty"—the longer a crisis persists, the less additional funding it attracts relative to its severity. This creates a perverse incentive structure where acute, short-term emergencies receive disproportionate attention while protracted crises affecting hundreds of millions receive inadequate sustained support.

3. Systematic Underfunding of Regional Response Plans

What the data shows: Regional response plans receive only 20.7% average funding compared to 33.9% for humanitarian needs/response plans, despite representing 50 of 87 plans (57%) and \$8.5B in gaps. Regional plans also show the highest funding volatility (standard deviation 25.2 percentage points) and include both the most overfunded (138%) and most underfunded (1%) plans.

Why it matters analytically: This pattern suggests a categorical bias in funding allocation. Regional plans—which typically address refugee/displacement responses across multiple countries—are systematically treated as lower priority than in-country humanitarian operations, regardless of their severity scores. The high volatility indicates these plans are also more vulnerable to funding withdrawal.

4. Accelerating Funding Deterioration: 82% of Plans Declining Year-Over-Year

What the data shows: Of 77 plans with comparable 2024-2025 data, 63 (82%) experienced funding declines, with an average drop of -23.8 percentage points among declining plans. Total funding fell from \$24.85B to \$15.94B (-\$8.9B, -36%) while requirements decreased only slightly (\$49.15B to \$45.30B). Structurally neglected plans experienced steeper declines (-18.4 pp average) than non-neglected plans (-12.4 pp).

Why it matters analytically: This is not random variation—it represents a systematic contraction of the humanitarian funding base. The 2024-2025 period saw average funding coverage drop from 45.7% to 28.7%, while average gap scores increased from 0.209 to 0.275. This suggests a structural shift in donor behavior, not merely a reallocation among competing priorities.

5. Operating Environment Paradox: Extreme Constraints Correlate with Better Funding

What the data shows: Plans with extreme operating environment constraints (9-10 score) receive 36.4% average funding, compared to 25.5% for plans with low constraints (<5). The correlation between operating environment score and funding percentage is positive (0.191), meaning harder-to-reach areas get slightly more funding. However, extreme constraint plans also have the highest absolute gaps (\$16.66B of \$29.36B total).

Why it matters analytically: This contradicts the expected pattern where operational difficulty would deter funding. The positive correlation suggests donors may use operating environment scores as a proxy for severity/urgency. However, the massive absolute gaps indicate that while these plans receive relatively more funding, they still fall far short of requirements—suggesting donors recognize the severity but are unwilling to fully fund the higher costs of operating in constrained environments.

6. Scale Matters: Mega-Plans Receive Better Coverage But Dominate Absolute Gaps

What the data shows: Plans with >\$2B requirements (8 plans) receive 39.9% average funding, compared to 23.3% for \$100-500M plans (29 plans). However, these 8 mega-plans account for \$14.42B in gaps (49% of total) despite representing only 9% of all plans. The relationship between scale and gap score is positive—larger plans have higher average gap scores (0.479 for mega-plans vs 0.126 for micro-plans).

Why it matters analytically: This reveals a concentration dynamic—a small number of very large crises dominate the funding landscape. While these mega-plans receive relatively better percentage coverage, their absolute gaps are so large that they consume half the total funding

shortfall. This creates a zero-sum competition where funding one mega-crisis necessarily means underfunding dozens of smaller ones.

7. Geographic Concentration: 10 Countries Account for 66% of Total Funding Gap

What the data shows: Lebanon, Sudan, Syria, DRC, Yemen, Afghanistan, Palestine, Somalia, Myanmar, and Chad collectively represent \$15.6B in funding gaps out of \$29.36B total (53%). All 10 are flagged for structural neglect. The tropical/equatorial zone (0-30°N) contains 44 plans with \$14.82B in gaps, while the northern zone (>30°N) has 18 plans with \$10.87B.

Why it matters analytically: The humanitarian funding crisis is not globally distributed—it is concentrated in a specific set of protracted conflicts and complex emergencies, primarily in Africa and the Middle East. This concentration suggests that addressing the funding gap requires targeted interventions in a relatively small number of countries, rather than system-wide reforms affecting all 70 countries with plans.

8. Visibility Bias: High-Profile Crises Defy Severity-Funding Relationship

What the data shows: Ukraine (severity 0.92, op env 10.0) receives 65% funding, Palestine (0.85, 10.0) receives 65%, and Myanmar (0.88, 10.0) receives 74%—all well above the 20-30% average for similarly severe crises. These three plans have gap scores of 0.18-0.29, far below the 0.45+ threshold for "severely overlooked" despite maximum operating environment constraints.

Why it matters analytically: This demonstrates that geopolitical visibility and media attention can override the severity-funding inverse relationship. These outliers prove that adequate funding is possible even for extreme-severity, high-constraint environments—but only when donor governments have strategic or political interests. The existence of these well-funded outliers makes the underfunding of comparable crises (Yemen, DRC, Somalia) even more striking.

9. Extreme Volatility in Small Regional Plans

What the data shows: Kenya's Rohingya response dropped from 153% to 5% funding (-148 pp), while Philippines' plan jumped from 65% to 148% (+83 pp). Six of the eight most volatile plans are regional response plans (RRHOAY, RETHKENUGA, RREG, RDRC_RRP). Small plans (<\$100M) show 30.8% average funding but with the lowest gap scores (0.126), suggesting they're either fully funded or completely abandoned.

Why it matters analytically: This extreme volatility indicates that small regional plans operate in a fundamentally different funding environment than large humanitarian plans. They appear to be treated as discretionary or supplementary, subject to dramatic swings based on donor priorities. This creates planning uncertainty and suggests these plans may be funded opportunistically rather than based on systematic need assessment.

10. Invisible Crises: 8 Countries with Documented Severity But No Plans

What the data shows: Mauritania (INFORM severity 6.1, "High", Increasing trend) has no humanitarian response plan despite documented need from drought, floods, and displacement. Seven other countries (Eritrea 5.9, Thailand 5.7, Algeria 5.7, Indonesia 5.6, Namibia 5.3, Morocco 5.2, Jamaica 5.1) also show medium-to-high severity without formal plans.

Why it matters analytically: This reveals a coverage gap in the humanitarian response architecture itself. The dataset captures only countries with formal plans—but severity data shows additional countries with documented need that fall outside the coordinated response system. This suggests the \$29.36B funding gap understates the true global humanitarian financing shortfall, as it excludes countries without plans entirely.

Cross-Cutting Observations

Funding allocation is driven by visibility, not severity: The weak correlation between severity and funding (0.17), combined with high-profile outliers receiving 2-3x typical coverage, indicates that media attention and geopolitical interest are stronger predictors of funding than technical severity metrics.

The system penalizes persistence: Structurally neglected crises (18+ months at high severity) receive less funding growth despite higher need, and experience steeper year-over-year declines. This creates a perverse incentive where acute crises receive disproportionate attention while chronic crises affecting 99.7% of people in need are systematically underfunded.

Plan type matters more than severity: Regional response plans receive 20.7% funding regardless of severity, while humanitarian needs/response plans receive 33.9%—a 13 percentage point gap that persists across all severity levels. This categorical bias suggests institutional or donor preference structures that override need-based allocation.

The funding crisis is accelerating: The 2024-2025 period saw a 36% absolute funding decline and a 17 percentage point coverage drop, with 82% of plans experiencing deterioration. This is not a static equilibrium but a dynamic collapse of humanitarian financing capacity.